

Arthur's Seat - Grown-ups

UK Family Tour

The City the Volcanoes Built

Most capital cities are built on a river, a harbour, a crossroads. Edinburgh is built on the wreckage of volcanoes. You would never guess it strolling the streets today, because everything here has been quiet for an unimaginably long time. But the great rock under the Castle, the green hill you are about to climb, and half the humps and ridges the city drapes itself over are the roots of volcanoes that last erupted around three hundred and forty to three hundred and fifty million years ago, when Scotland lay near the equator and this was a hot, swampy coast. The fire went out long before the first dinosaurs. What you see now is only the plumbing left behind, the hard cores that cooled deep inside the volcanoes and were later scoured bare by Ice Age glaciers grinding across the land.

That is the first surprising thing about this place. The landscape came first, and the city arranged itself around it. A sheer crag made a fortress almost impossible to storm, so a castle went there, and a town grew down the sheltered slope behind it. The result is a capital with a genuine wild mountain sitting in the middle of it, Arthur's Seat, where you can stand among skylarks and gorse with the whole city and the sea laid out below, ten minutes from a coffee shop.

And there is a second surprise, quieter but larger. These same rocks are where people first worked out how old the Earth truly is. Edinburgh is more than a city on volcanoes. It is, in a real sense, the birthplace of the science that reads them. Both of those stories are under your feet today.

The Volcanoes Under the City

Picture Edinburgh's setting the way a geologist does, and the whole city snaps into a single shape repeated again and again. Start with the volcanoes. Around three hundred and forty million years ago a cluster of vents erupted here, throwing out ash and lava, and then fell silent. Over the ages that followed, wind and rain wore the soft outer cone away entirely. What survived was the hardest part, the solid rock that had cooled and set inside the volcano's throat, a plug of tough stuff the weather could barely touch. The Castle Rock is one such plug. Arthur's Seat is a bigger, more complicated tangle of them.

Then came the ice. During the last couple of million years, glaciers hundreds of feet thick flowed across this country from west to east, slow rivers of ice that behaved like sheets of sandpaper the size of a county. When a glacier met one of these hard volcanic plugs, it could not grind the rock down. Instead it split around it and swept on, stripping away the softer ground on either side, but leaving a long protected ramp of material in the sheltered lee behind. Geologists call the result a crag and tail. The crag is the tough rock that stood firm, usually with a cliff on the side the ice struck first. The tail is the gentle slope trailing away downwind of the ice, in the shelter the crag provided.

Once you know the shape, you see it everywhere. Edinburgh Castle sits on the crag, a vertical wall of rock on three sides, and the whole Old Town, the Royal Mile, runs straight down the tail behind it. That is not a coincidence of town planning. It is the fingerprint of a glacier, and the medieval city simply moved into the mould the ice left. Travel an hour west to Stirling and you find the exact same trick played

twice, another castle on another crag, another old town spilling down another tail. Two of Scotland's great strongholds, built on the identical landform, because in a country shaped like this the safest place to stand was always the rock the ice could not beat.

Deep Time, and a Mountain in the Middle of Town

Now for the idea that was born in this landscape, one of the biggest anyone has ever had. In the seventeen hundreds, most educated people in Europe believed the Earth was about six thousand years old, a figure reached by adding up the generations in the Bible. Then an Edinburgh man named James Hutton, a farmer and chemist with a restless mind, went walking among rocks like these and saw something that would not fit. He could see that solid rock had once been molten and forced up from below, and that other rock had been laid down grain by grain as mud on an ancient sea floor, then buried, hardened, lifted, and worn away, over and over. No single flood, no one act of creation could do that. It needed time on a scale the human mind can barely hold, millions upon millions of years, cycle after cycle. Hutton described a world with, in his words, no vestige of a beginning and no prospect of an end.

We now call this idea deep time, which simply means the almost unimaginable age of the Earth, so vast that a whole human lifetime is less than a blink. It is the foundation Charles Darwin later stood on, because evolution needs oceans of time to work, and Hutton had just shown the time was there. That is why Edinburgh is remembered as a birthplace of geology, and why Hutton is often called the father of the science. The rocks built the city, and then they taught the world to read the age of the planet.

And they left the city something else, something you can simply enjoy. Arthur's Seat is a true wild hill, a little over eight hundred feet high, with rough grass, rocky ridges, and buzzards riding the wind above it, and it sits inside a capital city a short walk from Parliament and the palace. Almost no other capital on Earth has anything quite like it. Kings and queens once hunted here. Today anyone can climb it for free. You are about to walk up the eroded heart of a volcano, in a park where nearly every hump has a story, on the very ground where deep time was first understood.

Salisbury Crags: Where Deep Time Was Discovered

The walk under Salisbury Crags takes you past one of the most important outcrops in the history of science. In the seventeen eighties, James Hutton, an Edinburgh farmer, chemist, and Enlightenment polymath, studied the junction where the Crags' dolerite sill meets the underlying sedimentary rock, and read in it something heretical. The igneous rock had been injected, molten, into pre-existing sediments. That meant the Earth was not a static creation but an engine: rocks eroding into sediment, sediment hardening, molten rock intruding, land uplifting, in cycles with, as he put it, no vestige of a beginning, no prospect of an end. Against the prevailing calculation of a roughly six-thousand-year-old Earth, Hutton's theory of seventeen eighty-eight required essentially unlimited time, and "deep time" is arguably Scotland's greatest export to human thought, the platform on which Darwin later stood. "Hutton's Section," the spot he studied, is marked along the Radical Road, the path built beneath the Crags in eighteen twenty to employ destitute weavers after a failed radical uprising, Walter Scott's idea, though rockfall closures have restricted it in recent years; the lower Crags path gives the same geology. The hill above is the eroded core of a Carboniferous volcano, some three hundred fifty million years old, its structure so instructively exposed by glaciation that Edinburgh became a cradle of geology partly by accident of scenery. You are hiking the textbook.

Related listening: Castle Rock and Arthur's Seat are siblings, vents of the same ancient volcano field. Listen back — "Castle Rock: Geology as Destiny" (Edinburgh Castle, Day 9). Related listening: The Old Town rides the volcano's tail; the climb takes you up the volcano itself. Listen back — "The Old Town: Vertical City" (Royal Mile & Old Town, Day 9).

Reading the Crags, and the Quarry That Nearly Ate Them

Now that you know what Hutton found here, learn to read the crags themselves, because they're not a backdrop, they're the evidence. Salisbury Crags is a sill: a sheet of molten rock, dolerite, that was squeezed sideways between older layers of sediment, roughly three hundred and fifty million years ago, and then cooled underground into hard, dark stone. Erosion and glaciers later stripped away the softer rock on top and in front, leaving this great tilted rampart standing proud. That hard igneous rock is what Edinburgh calls whinstone, and it matters more to this story than you'd think.

Walk round toward the south side of the hill and look up at Samson's Ribs, a run of tall, straight-sided stone columns, many of them roughly six-sided, standing shoulder to shoulder like organ pipes. They formed as a thick body of lava cooled and contracted, cracking into these regular columns, the same process that made the Giant's Causeway. It's one of the most dramatic pieces of geology in the city, and most visitors never walk round far enough to see it.

One twist nearly cost Edinburgh its most famous rocks. Whinstone is superb for paving, tough and hard-wearing, and for a long stretch of the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries the Crags were quarried hard for it. An estimated two hundred and seventy thousand tonnes of stone came out of the south quarry alone, and it was shipped off to pave streets far beyond Scotland, even the streets of London. Stand back and you can still see the great bitten-out faces the quarrymen left behind. The quarrying ate its way toward the very outcrops that made this place scientifically priceless, and it caused a genuine public outcry, one of Britain's early battles to protect a landscape, until the cutting was finally stopped.

And this is where a lovely piece of the legend lives. The story goes that Hutton's Section itself, the exact junction he studied, was spared from the quarrymen at Hutton's own request, deliberately preserved so the evidence would survive. Whether that request is strictly true or a story grown up around a great man, the section did survive, and you can walk right to it.

When you reach it, look for a tongue of the dark dolerite reaching down into paler, layered sedimentary rock beneath, and, if you look closely, thin fingers of the igneous rock injected into the sediment. That's the whole argument in a single view. The molten rock is clearly younger, forcing its way into layers that were already there. To Hutton's eye, that meant heat, movement, and above all time, oceans of it. You are looking at the actual outcrop that helped unshackle the age of the Earth.

The Radical Road and the Royal Wilderness

Look down to the foot of the crags and you'll pick out a made path running along beneath that towering wall of rock. That's the Radical Road, and its name carries one of the sharpest little stories in the park. In 1820, Scotland was raw with unrest. A short-lived rising, remembered as the Radical War, had just been put down, and among those left jobless and desperate were weavers from the west of the country, skilled cloth-workers whose trade was collapsing. To give some of them honest work, and perhaps to keep idle, angry hands busy, they were set to building this path along the base of Salisbury Crags. The suggestion, fittingly for Edinburgh, came from the novelist Walter Scott. So a road named for radicals was built by the very men the authorities most feared, stone by stone, beneath these cliffs.

There's a modern coda. Rockfall from the crags above has made the Radical Road genuinely hazardous, and it has been closed to walkers since 2018, with boulders coming down onto the very path those weavers laid. The lower paths still give you the same sweep of geology, so you lose nothing but the closest approach.

Now lift your eyes from that one path to the whole park around you, because its wildness is a kind of illusion. This has been royal ground for the better part of nine hundred years. Down below sits Holyrood, and the name itself means holy cross. King David the First founded Holyrood Abbey here in 1128, and the legend has him charging a stag on this very ground and being saved by a miraculous cross appearing between its antlers. True or not, the crown kept the land, and these hills became a royal hunting park, a place for kings to chase deer within sight of their palace.

In 1541 King James the Fifth had the park formally enclosed within a stone wall, fixing its boundaries much as they run today, and turning a stretch of open hill into a defined royal preserve. Over the centuries that followed, this same ground served as hunting chase, as parade ground where troops were reviewed, as duelling field where gentlemen settled quarrels at dawn, and, as the Radical Road reminds us, as a place to park the poor and the dangerous with a shovel and a task.

So the paradox of Arthur's Seat is that this rugged, rabbit-run, dragon-shaped wilderness in the heart of a capital city is not wild at all. It's a royal backyard that simply refused to be tamed into lawns and flowerbeds, a piece of raw Scotland that the monarchy fenced but never civilised. You're hiking a king's hunting ground that happens to be an extinct volcano, and it has worn every one of those roles without losing its nerve.

The Fort, the Terraces, and the View

Geology made this hill, but people have been climbing it for their own reasons for thousands of years, and the summit you're aiming for is not empty history. It's crowned by an Iron Age hillfort. Look along the eastern side for two low stony banks, the eroded ramparts of a fortification that barred the approach up the broad gully into the saddle between the main peak and Crow Hill beside it. And this fort has company: Holyrood Park held four hilltop strongholds in all, on Dunsapie, on Crow Hill, above Samson's Ribs, and on the Salisbury Crags themselves, a remarkably crowded prehistoric skyline. These were strongholds of the Votadini, the people later remembered in the early Welsh poem *Y Gododdin*, composed around the year six hundred, which mourns warriors who feasted in a hall near here and rode south to die in battle.

Before you leave the human landscape, look at the eastern slopes when the light rakes across them low and golden. You'll see long, level steps terracing the hillside, best viewed from the Duddingston side.

Those are cultivation terraces, cut by farmers to win flat, ploughable ground from a steep hill, and they're among the best-preserved examples in the Lothians. Most walkers march straight past two thousand years of agriculture without a glance.

Now, the reward. From the two-hundred-and-fifty-one-metre summit, the panorama is genuinely one of the finest in Britain, and worth orienting yourself properly. To the west, the Old Town streams down its ridge to Edinburgh Castle, perched on a volcanic plug that is a close geological cousin of the rock beneath your boots. To the north lies the broad Firth of Forth and, beyond it, the Kingdom of Fife, with the Forth bridges strung across the water some twelve miles off on a clear day. Swing east toward the sea and pick out the Bass Rock, a pale dome that is itself an old volcanic core, whitened each summer by one of the world's great gannet colonies, with the cone of North Berwick Law nearby, another volcanic remnant. To the south rise the green Pentland Hills, and on a rare, sparkling day you can catch the blue edge of the Highlands far to the north-west.

A word on the practical, because this is a real mountain in miniature. There are two very different ways up. The gentle option is the path traversing beneath Salisbury Crags, mostly level, huge on views, easy on the legs. The summit itself asks for a proper walk and a short rocky scramble, most kindly approached from the Dunsapie side to the east. And heed the rock: this dark basalt turns treacherously slick in the wet, so if the weather is against you, take the Crags path and save the summit for a dry day. Go early, and you may have the ramparts of the fort almost to yourself.

The Man Himself, and the Friend Who Rescued Him

You've heard what Hutton found in these rocks. Now meet the man, because he's a wonderful example of a very Edinburgh kind of genius, and because your timing could hardly be better. James Hutton was born in Edinburgh on the third of June, seventeen twenty-six, which means the year of your visit, twenty twenty-six, is his three hundredth birthday. This whole city is marking his tercentenary, and there's no better place to raise a mental glass to him than the foot of the very crags where he read the age of the world.

A practical word while we're on it. The Radical Road, the path that runs closest to Hutton's Section along the base of the crags, has been shut since a large rockfall in twenty eighteen. In this anniversary year, Historic Environment Scotland has been working to reopen the stretch that passes the section, with new fencing and warning signs, and it ran booked, ranger-led access to the spot for a fortnight around his birthday at the start of June. Whether the path itself is open on the day you visit is genuinely worth checking on the signboards at the foot of the crags. If it's still closed, you lose nothing of the story: the lower path gives you the same great tilted rampart and the same sweep of view, you simply can't press your palm to the exact junction where the molten rock met the sediment.

Hutton was not a professor in a gown. He trained in medicine, dabbled in chemistry, made a small fortune from a factory producing a chemical for dyeing cloth, and then, crucially, spent years as a working farmer in the Scottish Borders. That matters. A farmer watches soil wash off his fields into the streams year after year, and a curious farmer starts to wonder where all that lost earth goes, and how the land is ever renewed. Out of that slow, patient, ground-level watching came one of the biggest ideas in the history of science. He wasn't struck by lightning. He noticed things, for decades, until the pattern gave itself away.

He belonged to the astonishing circle we call the Scottish Enlightenment, the same Edinburgh that produced the philosopher David Hume and the economist Adam Smith. Hutton's closest friend was the chemist Joseph Black, the man who worked out the science of heat and discovered carbon dioxide, and he knew James Watt, whose improved steam engine was busy remaking the world. They met, ate, argued, and drank in a dining society, and it's a lovely thought that deep time was hatched not in a lecture hall but around a table of brilliant friends who happened to like each other's company.

And now the twist that nearly lost Hutton to history. He was a dreadful writer. His great book, published in seventeen ninety-five, is a dense, tangled, almost unreadable thicket of prose, and when he died in seventeen ninety-seven his revolutionary idea was in real danger of being buried with him, simply because hardly anyone could get through the pages. What saved it was friendship. A mathematician named John Playfair, who had known Hutton and understood him, spent five years turning that thicket into clear, elegant English, and published it in eighteen hundred and two. Playfair is the reason the world eventually listened. It's a quiet lesson worth carrying off this hill, that a great idea also needs a great explainer, or it dies in the dark.

Playfair gave us something else, too, the single most famous sentence ever written about deep time. He and Hutton once sailed along the coast to another spot, called Siccar Point, where the rocks show a staggering gap in time laid bare, and Playfair, gazing at it, wrote that the mind seemed to grow giddy by looking so far into the abyss of time. That's the feeling Hutton unlocked. Not a number, not a date, but a kind of vertigo, the dizziness of realising how unimaginably old the ground beneath you really is. The crags in front of you, where the molten rock forced its way into the older layers, tell one half of that story. Siccar Point tells the other. Between them, two Scottish outcrops, an Edinburgh farmer, and a loyal friend with a clear pen quietly rewrote the age of the Earth.

Arthur, Miniature Coffins, and a Park Full of Stories

Holyrood Park packs an improbable amount of legend into a royal backyard. The name Arthur's Seat is first recorded in the fifteenth century and its origin is genuinely unknown. The King Arthur connection is likely folk etymology, though Welsh-language tradition does place the historical Arthur's milieu in southern Scotland's Old North, so romantics are not entirely without a case. St Anthony's Chapel, the gaunt ruin above St Margaret's Loch, is a medieval hermitage of obscure purpose with commanding views of the Forth. May Day tradition has Edinburgh residents climbing the hill at dawn to wash their faces in the dew for beauty and luck, still practiced. And then there are the coffins: in June 1836, boys hunting rabbits on the hill's northeast slope found a concealed recess containing seventeen miniature coffins, each holding a dressed, carved wooden figure. Contemporary theories ran from witchcraft to sailors' charms; the modern favorite, argued in detail by researchers at the National Museum, links them to Burke and Hare's sixteen murder victims of eighteen twenty-seven to twenty-eight, plus the first, naturally dead body they sold: seventeen bodies denied burial, since dissection destroyed them, perhaps given surrogate funerals by someone who knew them, or knew guilt. Analysis suggests one maker, possibly a shoemaker by his tools, working around the right date. Eight coffins survive in the National Museum of Scotland. It remains unsolved, and it's a fittingly Edinburgh mystery: half science, half grave-robbing gothic, found by kids on a volcano.

The Coffins as Objects: What the Evidence Actually Says

Strip away the ghost-story glamour for a moment and look at the seventeen coffins as physical evidence, because the objects themselves are more eloquent than any theory. They were found in late June 1836, on the north-eastern slope of this hill, by boys hunting for rabbits, tucked into a small hollow and sealed behind three thin, pointed pieces of slate arranged like a little doorway. Not scattered, not dumped. Deliberately concealed and neatly stowed.

Each coffin is small, about ninety-five millimetres long, carved from a single block of wood and fitted with a lid. Whoever made them decorated the exteriors with lozenge-shaped pieces of tin, pressed into the surface in a regular pattern, so these were not careless offcuts but finished, considered things. Inside each lay a carved wooden figure, and here the detail turns telling. The figures appear to have begun life as toy soldiers, mass-produced little men, some of which had their arms cut away so they would lie flat in the box, then dressed in individually stitched and glued cloth garments. Someone took the cheerful and made it funereal, one figure at a time, seventeen times over.

The most careful modern study is the one to lean on. In 1994, in the *Book of the Old Edinburgh Club*, Samuel Menefee and Allen Simpson published the definitive analysis, and later museum examination has refined it. Their reading of the tool marks suggests a single maker, someone accustomed to working with sharp metal tools, plausibly in a trade like shoemaking or leatherwork rather than fine cabinetry, since the joinery is workmanlike rather than delicate. The style of the stitched clothing hints that the burials may have been assembled over a period of time rather than in one sitting, which is itself a clue about intent.

Eight of the seventeen survive, and even their afterlife is well documented. They passed through private hands and a sale, and in 1901 a woman named Christina Couper of Tynron, in Dumfriesshire, donated her eight coffins to what is now the National Museum of Scotland, where they remain on display. That good provenance is part of why these particular objects have never been dismissed as a hoax. Too much careful, consistent, laborious work went into them for a prank.

There is an honest boundary here, though, and it matters. Everything past the objects is inference. There is no note, no confession, no contemporary document naming a maker or a motive. The famous link to

Burke and Hare, which the next chapter takes up, rests on a coincidence of numbers and a matching of dates, not on proof. The coffins are real, their craftsmanship is real, their careful concealment is real. The story we hang on them is a hypothesis, the best we have, and a good docent will always tell you where the evidence stops and the storytelling begins.

The Park's Other Ghosts: Chapels, Cairns, and a Skating Minister

The coffins are the park's most famous mystery, but Holyrood Park is thick with quieter stories, and it rewards a walker who knows where to look. Start with the gaunt ruin on the rocky shoulder above St Margaret's Loch. That is St Anthony's Chapel, medieval, roofless now, with a single tall fragment still standing. Its exact origins are genuinely obscure, which is unusual for a stone building of any size. It may have been linked to a hospital of St Anthony down at Leith, or served pilgrims, or simply provided a dramatic place of devotion above the loch, its light kept as a guide for ships on the Forth. Below it once flowed St Anthony's Well, one of several springs on the hill that drew people seeking cures and, on the right morning, a little luck.

That luck brings us to a custom people still keep. On the first dawn of May, Edinburgh folk climb the hill to wash their faces in the morning dew, in an old belief that it brings beauty and good fortune for the year. It is one of the few genuinely surviving folk rituals of the city, and if you're here at the right season you'll find the summit strangely busy at first light.

Now for something darker. Somewhere on the low ground stands Muschat's Cairn, a heap of stones marking a real and grim event: the murder in 1720 of Margaret Muschat by her husband Nicol, whose name the cairn still carries. Walter Scott seized on the spot and made it unforgettable in his novel *The Heart of Midlothian*, setting a tense night-time meeting there, so the cairn now lives a double life, half true crime, half literary landmark. This is very Edinburgh, a real horror polished into a story you can visit.

And keep an eye on the shape of the hill itself, because the folklore insists it is a sleeping dragon, gorged and curled and turned to stone, its long spine the ridge you climb. It's a modern-ish tale rather than ancient gospel, but stand at the right angle and you'll see exactly why people tell it.

End on a gentler note, down at Duddingston Loch at the hill's south-eastern foot. This quiet water is the likely setting of one of Scotland's best-loved paintings, *The Skating Minister*, showing the Reverend Robert Walker gliding across the ice, long attributed to Sir Henry Raeburn and painted around the seventeen nineties, though some scholars now question whose hand it truly was. The original hangs in the Scottish National Gallery. So this single park gives you a haunted chapel, a wishing well, a murder immortalised in fiction, a stone dragon, and a national masterpiece on frozen water, all before you've even reached the summit.

Arthur, Camelot, and the Old North

Let's take the name head-on, because everyone wants Arthur's Seat to mean what it says, and the truth is both more uncertain and more interesting. The name is first recorded only in the fifteenth century, and its real origin is unknown. The romantic link to King Arthur, with a whisper of Camelot and knights asleep beneath the hill, is almost certainly folk etymology, a later ear making comfortable sense of an older, stranger word. Rival guesses abound. Some derive it from Gaelic, along the lines of Àrd-na-Said, a phrase read as the height of arrows or the height of the ridge. Others prefer a plainer Archer's Seat. The honest position is that these are all conjecture, and no one has settled it. The hill kept its oldest name to itself.

But one twist gives the Arthurian dream a flicker of legitimacy. This region really was, in the centuries after Rome withdrew, the heartland of a heroic warrior culture, and it spoke a Brythonic language, a cousin of Welsh, not yet the Scots or Gaelic we might expect. Historians call this vanished world the Old North. The people here were the Votadini, later remembered as the Gododdin, and their great stronghold,

Din Eidyn, most likely stood on the Castle Rock across the valley from you, the fortified seed from which Edinburgh itself grew.

From that world comes one of the oldest surviving pieces of literature composed in Britain, the poem *Y Gododdin*, attributed to the bard Aneirin and reaching back to around the year six hundred. It commemorates a war band of picked warriors who feasted and drank in the hall at Din Eidyn for a year, then rode south to attack their enemies at a place called Catraeth, where nearly all of them were killed. It is elegy, not chronicle, a roll-call of the beautiful doomed, and it belongs to these very hills. Tantalisingly, the poem contains a passing comparison of one hero to Arthur, one of the earliest mentions of that name anywhere, which is not proof of a real king but does show the legend was already in the air in exactly this landscape.

So set the fantasy of Camelot gently aside, and pick up something better. You are standing in the Old North, on ground held by a real Brythonic warrior aristocracy whose deeds were sung when the memory of Rome was still fresh. Their neighbours held other volcanic strongholds you can see from here, like Traprain Law away to the east. The name on the map may be a medieval misunderstanding, but the heroic age it accidentally points to was real, and it happened right where you're standing. That, in the end, is the pattern of this whole hill: reach for the legend, and you fall through it into something older, stranger, and true.

Three Lochs, and the Volcano You'll See Again Tonight

Look around the park and you'll count three sheets of water. What surprises almost everyone is that two of them are entirely artificial, built to make a scene. This wild-looking royal wilderness was, in places, carefully landscaped.

Start with Saint Margaret's Loch, the pretty stretch of water below Saint Anthony's Chapel, usually busy with swans, geese, and a hopeful crowd of ducks. It looks as though it has always been there. It hasn't. It was created in eighteen fifty-six as part of Prince Albert's improvement scheme for the ground around the palace. Albert, Queen Victoria's husband, took a keen personal interest in Holyrood Park, and the boggy hollow here was dammed and drained, with water led down from Hunter's Bog above, to make a picturesque loch where there had been marsh. The carriage road that loops the park, Queen's Drive, belongs to the same royal makeover. It's named for Victoria, and it's the reason you can drive, cycle, or stroll a smooth circuit round a volcano. The loch takes its name from Saint Margaret, the pious eleventh-century queen of Malcolm the Third, later canonised, whose memory clings to several spots in this royal landscape.

Higher up sits the second made loch, Dunsapie, tucked below Dunsapie Hill and framing one of the finest views in the park, and it too was formed in that same Victorian scheme rather than by nature. If your route brings you past it, know that you're looking at nineteenth-century stagecraft, a mirror set among the crags on purpose.

The third loch is the real one. Duddingston Loch, at the south-eastern foot of the hill, is a genuine natural body of water, and it's the wild heart of the park's nature. It became a bird sanctuary in the nineteen twenties, one of the earliest in the country, and it holds the largest reedbed in the Lothians, a dense green world of common reed alive with breeding and wintering wildfowl. It also has a sporting claim to fame, for the game of curling is traditionally said to have been played and shaped on its frozen surface, complete with its own little Curling House on the shore. So of your three lochs, two were dreamed up to please the Victorian eye, and one has quietly done its wild work for millennia.

Now lift your gaze and connect the dots, because tonight some of your party may head up Calton Hill for the sunset, so carry this thread up with you. Calton Hill, that green rise crowned with columns and monuments across the valley, is not a separate thing. It's a broken-off fragment of this very volcano, part

of the same ancient system as Arthur's Seat and the Castle Rock, sheared away and shunted along a fracture in the ground called the Calton Fault. Its lavas and ashes are close cousins of the rock beneath your boots, laid down when this corner of the Earth was a smoking volcanic province some three hundred and forty million years ago. So when you watch the sun go down from Calton Hill this evening, you'll be standing on the same volcano you climbed this morning, just a piece of it that wandered off. Edinburgh isn't a city with a volcano in it. It's a city built across the bones of one, and today you get to visit three of its scattered ribs in a single day.

The Sheep Heid Inn and the Village Below

Tuck this one away for later, because it's the ideal reward at the end of a hill day. At the south-eastern foot of Arthur's Seat, below the wild loch, sits the old village of Duddingston, and in it stands a pub with a claim that stops people mid-sentence. The Sheep Heid Inn, *heid* being the Scots for head, says there has been an inn on this spot since thirteen sixty. If that founding date holds, it would make it perhaps the oldest surviving licensed premises in Edinburgh, and quite possibly in all of Scotland. Be a good sceptic, as this hill teaches you to be: the present building is largely eighteenth century with later additions, and the medieval date is tradition rather than documented proof. But an inn of some kind has plausibly stood here for a very long time, and the sheer continuity is remarkable.

The name is refreshingly literal. From the Middle Ages onward, sheep were reared on the slopes of Holyrood Park, the very ground you've been walking, and Duddingston was where they were slaughtered before the meat went up to the Fleshmarket in the Old Town. A village defined by sheep, an inn named for their heads. There's nothing coy about it.

Royalty threads through the story, as it does everywhere in this park. Mary, Queen of Scots, is said to have passed this way, and her son, James the Sixth of Scotland, who became James the First of England, reputedly enjoyed the place considerably. The pub's signature legend has him so delighted after a visit in fifteen eighty that he presented the landlord with an extraordinary gift: an ornate snuff box fashioned from a ram's head, horns and all, a nod to the inn's name. The original apparently stayed on the premises for some three centuries before being sold to the Earl of Rosebery, whose family is said to hold it still at Dalmeny House, and a nineteenth-century copy sits behind the bar. Like the founding date, treat the tale with a raised eyebrow and enjoy it anyway. It is exactly the sort of burnished, half-true, wholly delightful story that clings to a place this old.

Duddingston itself repays a wander. Its kirk, the parish church above the loch, is genuinely medieval, one of the oldest churches still in use in Scotland, and at its gate you'll find a *loupin-on stane*, an old mounting block for climbing onto a horse, and *jougs*, an iron collar once used to shame wrongdoers. The village sits, rather grandly, at the exact midpoint between two royal residences, Holyrood Palace and Craigmillar Castle, which is why crowned heads kept passing through. So this is your itinerary's neat closing bracket: climb the volcano, come down the far side, and finish in a village where sheep were counted, kings played, and an inn has been pouring drinks, if the story holds, since before the printing press existed. Which brings us to what the king supposedly played there, and that deserves its own moment.

The Oldest Skittle Alley in the Land

What the king was supposedly playing when he handed over that ram's-head snuff box was skittles, and the Sheep Heid still has a skittle alley behind it that lays claim to being the oldest surviving one in Scotland. It's a lovely, unglamorous piece of living heritage, and unlike a museum case, you can still book it and play.

Skittles is the venerable European ancestor of the ten-pin bowling you know from a Saturday afternoon out. You stand pins, traditionally nine of them, at the far end of a long, narrow lane, and you roll a ball or hurl a shaped wooden cheese down the boards to knock them flat. It's a game of centuries, played in inn yards and alleys across Britain long before it crossed the Atlantic and grew neon and automatic. Here at the Sheep Heid, the setting keeps its old bones.

The present skittles hall was built in eighteen eighty-two, which itself makes it a Victorian antique, but the pub is clear that a game was set up in the courtyard here well before that, in the days when Stuart

kings were the ones rolling the ball. The set still in use is a genuine nineteenth-century one, so when you play, you're knocking down antique pins on a floor that has heard a hundred and forty years of the same satisfying wooden clatter.

There's something quietly moving about that continuity, and it fits this whole day rather well. You've spent the morning reading time in the rocks, deep time, millions upon millions of years pressed into a cliff. Here is human time instead, small and warm and unbroken: the same simple pleasure of rolling a ball at a row of pins, carried on in the same yard, generation after generation, from a king in fifteen eighty to a family in twenty twenty-six. Book the alley if you can, roll a few, and enjoy being the newest link in a very long, very ordinary, very happy chain.

The Innocent Railway

Here's a piece of history most visitors never suspect, running quite literally beneath the edge of the park you're walking. In eighteen thirty-one, one of Scotland's very first railways opened here, the Edinburgh and Dalkeith Railway, and it drove the first railway tunnel the country ever had, more than five hundred metres long, under the southern flank of Holyrood Park from a terminus at Saint Leonard's. It survives today as a walking and cycling path, tunnel and all, and it carries one of the best nicknames in transport history. Everyone called it the Innocent Railway.

Why innocent? Not for any moral reason, but because in its early years it was worked not by steam but by horses. Cast your mind back to how alarming the first steam locomotives were to ordinary people. They were loud, fast, smoke-belching iron monsters, and there was genuine public fear about the speeds and the danger. This gentle line, with its wagons drawn by plodding horses, felt reassuringly safe by comparison, so harmless that people affectionately dubbed it the innocent one. The name outlasted the horses by well over a century.

It was built, like so much early railway, to move coal, hauling loads from the Lothian pits into the hungry city. Between a hundred and thirty and a hundred and ninety wagons a day could be worked up the incline to the coal depot at Saint Leonard's. Through the long tunnel, where horses were of little use in the dark, the wagons were pulled by a rope wound in by a stationary steam engine, a neat hybrid of muscle and machine. Then came the twist that makes it charming. An enterprising operator named Michael Fox put a passenger coach on the rails, and Edinburgh took to it with startling appetite. In the first month alone the line carried something like fourteen thousand passengers. People simply loved riding the safe, sedate horse-railway out toward Duddingston and beyond.

The Innocent was eventually swallowed by the roaring age of proper steam it had once made people feel safe from, and the tracks fell quiet. But the route lives on beautifully. You can walk the old line and pass right through that pioneering tunnel, cool and dim and dead straight, with the bulk of Arthur's Seat resting on the rock above your head. Stand in it for a moment and consider the layering of this place: a Carboniferous volcano up top, an Iron Age fort on its summit, a royal hunting ground on its slopes, and threaded beneath it all, a horse-drawn railway from the dawn of the modern age. Few square miles anywhere carry so many chapters of the human and the deep-time story stacked so neatly on top of one another. You have been walking through all of them at once.